

Heart of Practice

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At the heart of my practice, I am guided by the belief that artistic media can bridge gaps, foster connection, and cultivate meaningful engagement across mediums. Whether through web design, creative code, or more analog practices (film photography, crochet, etc.), I approach each project with the primary goal of creating spaces that feel participatory, reflective, and joyful. I view my practice as a dynamic conversation between artist, audience, and medium, rather than a static artifact. My philosophy draws from a range of conceptual and theoretical frameworks that inform how I think about design, storytelling, and interaction. Participatory Design, Embodied Cognition, Multimodality, and Playful Engagement are practical frameworks that guide the way I approach and build all of my projects. Exploring these concepts in depth and situating them within both theoretical discourse and my own creative practice allows me to articulate the intellectual underpinnings of my work. Ultimately, these concepts demonstrate how my practice seeks to balance accessibility and experimentation, creating digital and physical works that invite others to connect, reflect, and play.

Participatory design emerged in the 1970s as part of a Scandinavian workplace democracy movement, where designers sought to empower workers by including them in the creation of technologies that would shape their daily lives (Ehn, 1993). At its core, participatory design challenges the “top-down” approach of traditional design by centering collaboration, interactivity, and co-creation. Rather than treating audiences as passive consumers, participatory design treats them as active contributors whose

voices shape both process and outcome. This ethos deeply informs my creative process, particularly in web design and creative coding. I approach projects not as finished products to be delivered, but as evolving systems where the users' participation matters. In designing community focussed websites, for example, I prioritize tools for dialogue (comment forums, interactive components, etc.) and design choices that invite users into the process of creating. The goal is not simply to make a functional project, but to build an environment where users actively shape meaning. Beyond the technical, participatory design also reflects a larger commitment: Accessibility. Designing with participation in mind ensures that digital experiences are not gatekept by exclusivity, but instead remain open, adaptable, and democratic. In this sense, my work aligns with Pelle Ehn's assertion that design is not just about creating objects, but about cultivating systems of communication and participation (Ehn, 1993). By applying these principles, I strive to create interactive works, such as [*Breaking News*](#) (interactive lighthearted news platform), that are living platforms for shared engagement.

Building on the social frameworks of participation, I also find inspiration in theories of embodied cognition, which remind me that creativity is not only a mental activity but also a deeply physical and sensory one. In *Philosophy in the Flesh: The Embodied Mind and Its Challenge to Western Thought*, George Lakoff and Mark Johnson argued that cognition is not purely abstract or computational; it is grounded in the ways we

physically move, sense, and interact with the world (George Lakoff and Mark Johnson, 1999). Similarly, in *The Embodied Mind: Cognitive Science and Human Experience* and *Being There: Putting Brain, Body, and World Together Again*, Francisco Varela and Andy Clark emphasized how perception, action, and thought are deeply intertwined (Varela, 1992; Clark, 1996). This idea of placing emphasis on embodied cognition within the role of creation and interactivity has shaped my practice, as I regularly shift between/combine digital and physical modes of creation. My project [*matchayan*](#), for example, allows users to engage with a digital platform in more “tangible” ways, as they are given space to create using the website's features. Each of these mediums produces not only different outcomes, but also different ways of thinking. My work shooting on film, for example, requires patience, attunement to light, and an embodied awareness of time and texture that differs radically from the instant feedback of digital photography/video. That physical, sensory process fundamentally shapes the kinds of stories I tell and the aesthetic decisions I make. By grounding my work in embodied cognition, I resist the abstraction of digital culture that often divorces art from lived, tactile experience. Instead, I am to create hybrid practices where the materiality of analog methods informs the interactivity of digital ones. This interplay keeps my practice rooted in the human scale, reminding both myself and my audience that art is not only seen or clicked, but also felt.

Just as embodied cognition demonstrates the importance of sensory and material experience, multimodality expands this idea into the communicative realm, showing how meaning is

constructed across multiple modes at once. In *Multimodality: A Social Semiotic Approach to Contemporary Communication* and *Multimodality and Literacy in School Classrooms*, Gunther Kress and Carey Jewitt highlighted how multimodality is central to contemporary communication, particularly in digital contexts where audiences encounter layered media at once (Kress, 2009; Jewitt, 2008). Personally, I believe that multimodality is not just a description of contemporary media but a guiding principle for design. Much of my work exists at the intersection of disciplines: Coding interactive websites that integrate text, sound, and motion graphics; editing video projects where narrative is communicated through the interplay of dialogue, music, and image; or designing brand identities where copywriting and visual language must work together. In each of these cases, the impact is derived, not from a single mode, but from the synergy among them. A specific example of this is my work on [*Unweaving*](#), which combines storytelling text with interactive code driven visuals. Here, the words may provide narrative grounding, but the slight interactivity gives audiences a sense of agency in how they encounter and interpret the story. This layering produces richer experiences that mirror the multimodal ways people already navigate a media-saturated world.

At the intersection of the aforementioned ideas lies playful engagements, which underscores the emotional and affective dimensions of design, where experimentation and pleasure become essential to meaning-making. Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1950) argued that play is a foundational element of culture, not a frivolous distraction. Later came Brian Sutton-Smith's *The Ambiguity of Play* (2001), which elaborated on the concept that play always carries a serious cultural meaning and takes shape in several forms including ritual, competition, improvisation. Together, these theories highlight that play is a mode of inquiry and connection. In my practice, I treat play not as an afterthought, but as a methodology. Designing interactive projects often involves creating interfaces where audiences are encouraged to explore, experiment, or break the system. My project [*Birds Etc.*](#) builds on these actions, as the space places the user within an exploratory environment where they are free to roam and manipulate perspective. These playful interactions lower barriers to entry, inviting users to engage with art in ways that feel intuitive and joyful. In my coding practice especially, I aim to build experiences where discovery and curiosity are built into the interface. An important distinction to make is that playful engagement does not equal trivialization: Instead, it acknowledges that joy, curiosity, and exploration are powerful entry points for deeper reflection. A playful website or installation can invite audiences to consider serious themes precisely because the experience disarms them and makes space for curiosity. For me, play is both a design tool and a philosophical stance: It insists that art is not simply consumed, but lived.

Taken together, these concepts do not enclose my work in a neat framework so much as propel it forward. Thinking through participation, embodiment, multimodality, and play expands how I imagine both the possibilities and responsibilities of art and design. These concepts suggest that the act of creation is not to be executed in a solitary manner: Instead, creation should be executed with dialogue in mind. As I continue experimenting across mediums, I want my work to remain interdisciplinary, adaptable, and open to the unexpected encounters that these theories encourage.